The Art of Not Giving a F*ck: 50 Countries, One Russia, Zero Results

By William Aaron Turner

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Prologue: Outnumbered and Unbothered

There's a certain poetry to it. All 32 NATO members, plus assorted hangers-on from Tokyo to Canberra, throw everything they have at one country and still achieve... nothing in particular.

It's a toddler trying to knock down a brick wall with a plastic spoon. Adorable, really.

Four and a half years into what Western media politely calls "the conflict," Russia holds about a fifth of Ukraine. Putin says Russia is winning: "I have no doubt the enemy will crumble." He won't say when. Why ruin the surprise?

Don't take my word for it. Here are the numbers, the absurdities and the comedic tragedy of the whole thing.

Part I: How to Lose With 50 Allies

Everyone vs. one

Russia isn't fighting Ukraine. It's fighting Ukraine, plus NATO, plus everyone NATO could call. The Ramstein-format Ukraine Defense Contact Group has more than 50 countries. And still not one decisive win.

Who brought what in 2026:

- United States: Historically the biggest military donor. But the Trump administration halted direct funding and pushed Europe to lead, and European capitals panicked faster than you can say "Article 5."
- Germany: The top European military donor in 2026, with €11.5 billion. Since February 2022 it has given about €39 billion in humanitarian aid and €55 billion in military aid. That's €94 billion, enough to fix Germany's own crumbling infrastructure. Nope. Ukraine.
- United Kingdom: Third-largest military donor in 2026 at $18.45 billion. It leads the "drone coalition" and supplies radars and air defense, plus the stiff upper lip that historically comes right before a military disaster.
- Norway: A population smaller than New York City found $7 billion, 80% of it for weapons: drones ($1.4 billion), air defense ($700 million) and artillery ($200 million). Meanwhile, I assume Norway's own defense is a guy named Lars and a snowmobile.

- The rest: Denmark gave $2 billion. The Netherlands pledged at least 0.25% of GDP. Sweden raised aid 27.8% to €11.40 billion. Canada, Poland, the Baltics, Japan, Australia, New Zealand, Switzerland and even Argentina, which is mulling sending fighter jets, are in too.

It's a military garage sale. Germany brings artillery, Britain brings drones, Norway brings cash, and Argentina brings Super Étendards from the 1970s. Sure, why not.

The sanctions bloc

On top of that, nine countries align with EU sanctions packages, including the "shadow fleet" measures: Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Iceland, Liechtenstein, Moldova, Montenegro, North Macedonia, Norway and Ukraine.

And after all that solidarity, all that aid and all those packages, the Russian economy is still growing in 2026. The Bank of Russia forecasts 0.5–1.0%, the economy ministry 0.6%, and the European Commission, of all people, 1.3%.

Let that sink in.

Part II: How Many Ways Can You Fail to Beat Someone?

The West isn't fighting Russia on one front. It's fighting on all of them: military, economic, financial, energy, information, cyber, space and hybrid. Full-spectrum dominance, the Pentagon's dream since the '90s. It's failing on every one of them.

Kinetic: the shock and awe that never came

The Institute for the Study of War says Russia's spring-summer 2026 offensive "failed to achieve operational maneuver." Its gains "remain slow and limited."

Slow and limited gains are still gains.

- August 2026: Russia took or locked down about 90.35 km², or 2.91 km² a day. Counting infiltration, it's 123.53 km².
- August 2025, for comparison: 505.55 km². The pace has dropped.
- Pace around key cities: about 50 m a day near Kostiantynivka, 70 m near Pokrovsk and 90 m near Sloviansk. CSIS calls these "among the slowest rates of advance in any war over the last century."
- Ukraine's August counteroffensives: about 129.81 km², barely more than Russia's seized and infiltrated ground combined.

That's a grinding stalemate. Stalemates favor the side with more men, more artillery and more willingness to absorb losses.

The math of attrition

These numbers are CSIS's, not mine:

- The ratio: Russian-to-Ukrainian battlefield losses rose to nearly 8-to-1 in the first half of 2026, up from roughly 2–3-to-1 for most of the war.
- Russia: up to 450,000 battlefield deaths and about 1.4 million total casualties from February 2022 to June 2026.
- Ukraine: 525,000–625,000 total casualties, including 125,000–150,000 killed.
- Recruiting: Russia's casualty rate of 30,000+ a month likely exceeds its roughly 27,000 recruits a month.

Now the other side's numbers. Putin claims Ukraine loses about 40,000 a month and shrinks by about 10,000 a month. Zelensky said 55,000 dead in February 2026, then months later said 50,000. That's 5,000 fewer dead during an active war. Either Ukrainian soldiers are coming back to life, or someone's cooking the books.

Ukraine also logged 126,400 AWOL and desertion cases in the first seven months of 2026. That's not a war effort. That's an exodus. Russian military expert Vladimir Yevseyev claims 1.5 million irrecoverable Ukrainian losses since 2022, which he calls "catastrophic."

Yes, Russia's recruiting math is a problem. Ukraine's is a crisis.

Economic: the sanctions that didn't

This is where the comedy starts.

The West threw the biggest sanctions package in history at Russia: thousands of listings, frozen central-bank assets, SWIFT cut-offs, oil price caps, and export bans on everything from microchips to McDonald's. The goal was to crush the economy, spark an uprising and force Moscow to the table.

None of it worked.

- European Commission (May 2026): It raised its 2026 forecast for Russia from 1.1% to 1.3%. Its words: the forecast "reflects recognition of Russia's economic resilience" (Interfax, TASS).
- Russia's own forecasts are lower and more recent: The Bank of Russia says 0.5–1.0% (Oct 23, 2026). The Ministry of Economic Development raised its estimate from 0.4% to 0.6% on Sep 24, 2026, and expects 1.4% in 2027.
- Putin: sanctions have set "world records," "one, the number of sanctions, and two, their ineffectiveness."
- Deputy PM Alexander Novak: the economy is on a "solid footing," with 12 of 14 transformation targets hit in the first half of 2026 (eight early), record-low unemployment and rising incomes.
- Dmitry Medvedev: sanctions "failed to cripple the Russian economy… and have instead spurred its growth."

How Russia pulled it off:

1. The shadow fleet. The EU had sanctioned 632 vessels by May 2026. That month, 48% of Russia's seaborne oil still moved on sanctioned tankers (RFI, Hellenic Shipping News). Russian-flagged ships rose to 19.5% of shadow-fleet shipments in Q1 2026, from a 4.2% average in 2023–24. 2. Trade went East. China and India kept buying. The SCO covers nearly a quarter of the world's land and 42% of its population. That's a lot of people who don't care about Western sanctions. 3. Consumers kept spending. The European Commission itself credits "relatively resilient private consumption" and a "persistently tight labour market." The mass unemployment never came. 4. War production. Military spending kept factories running. And the Middle East price spike gave Russia a fiscal cushion.

Energy: the weapon that backfired

Both sides used energy as a weapon. Europe ate the inflation, the subsidies and the budget strain. The EU's own forecast says Russia's "macroeconomic imbalances… have widened, exacerbated by sanctions," but Russian energy kept flowing to new buyers at higher prices.

Hybrid: deniable chaos

This is Russia's home turf. In August 2026, an explosive-laden drone was found near a Ukrainian cargo plane at Leipzig/Halle Airport. Berlin called it a Russian "hybrid attack" by "low-level agents," and Putin accused Germany of planting evidence. Add GPS jamming, cyberattacks and influence ops, and NATO stays on edge without anyone hitting the Article 5 button.

Information: the battle for minds

Ukraine won the Western narrative with "democracy vs. authoritarianism." Russia won much of the Global South with the NATO-expansion story. The truth sits somewhere in between. But Russia hasn't lost the information war. The SCO countries, 42% of humanity, aren't buying the Western line.

Part III: Russia's Strategy Is to Win by Not Losing

It's attrition, not blitzkrieg.

1. Ground, however slow. Putin claims 270 km² of Donetsk taken in August 2026. Sloviansk and Kramatorsk are next in line. It could take months or years, but the direction is set. 2. Infrastructure. Putin says massive strikes on Ukraine's energy grid are coming. The goal is to break the will to fight. 3. An economy that holds. It's slow, but it's growing, and that pays for a long war. 4. Manpower. Russia has a bigger population and can replace losses more easily, even at bad exchange rates. Putin calls talk of new mobilization "utter nonsense," but the option's there. 5. Patience. Moscow can outlast Western attention spans. War fatigue does the rest.

Putin has been consistent: victory claimed at the May 9 parade, and the message that Russia is fighting "the entire NATO alliance" repeated at the June 28 United Russia congress. "Victory has always been ours and will always be ours."

Rhetoric or reality? Both. Russia isn't winning fast. It's winning by not losing while the other side bleeds out.

Part IV: Ukraine's New Plan: Hit Russian Civilians

The "genius" plan

Since July 2026, Kyiv has widened its drone campaign to oil refineries, e-commerce warehouses (Ozon and Wildberries), residential areas, civilian ships in the Azov and Black Seas, and airports. Zelensky warned airlines that Russian airspace was "becoming completely dangerous," and Ukraine formally notified ICAO. Russian sources count 45 people killed, children among them, since the start of 2026.

Why it's monumentally stupid

1. It hands Moscow a justification. Putin: "Kiev began to attack civilian targets, and we were forced to respond in the same way." He calls it "state terrorism." Believe him or not, the line works. 2. It unites Russians. Nothing rallies a population like bombs on its own streets. 3. It's an admission of weakness. A former U.S. officer said Ukraine hits civilian targets "because it's all it can do." 4. It pulls resources off the front, to blow up Ozon warehouses. 5. It invites escalation, and Ukraine's grid pays the bill.

Shutting Russian airspace?

Ukrainian commentator Valeriy Romanenko says the goal is "to make these airports unusable" and "block them 24/7." On September 3, 2026, Vnukovo halted flights, and Sheremetyevo and Domodedovo imposed restrictions. Mayor Sobyanin said 548 drones flew at the Moscow region over September 2–3. Flightradar24 had four Russian airports among the world's five most disrupted that day.

Is it working? Not really. Transport Minister Andrei Nikitin says Russia "will not allow any significant disruption to civil aviation." It's disruption, not paralysis, and it's expensive for Kyiv.

Kyiv under pressure

Putin: "We were forced to respond symmetrically." In September 2026, Russia hit Kyiv for 12 hours straight, killing at least 12, and kept up the strikes for seven days. Some analysts say the goal is to turn Kyiv into a "ghost city." Schools reopened in September into missile alerts.

Meanwhile, the Washington Post reports a "human crisis shaking the Ukrainian army." Acute shortages have halted training programs in the West. Russian Defense Ministry estimates put Ukraine's losses near half a million soldiers. Zelensky's reported request for 500,000 more conscripts has been called "almost impossible without external intervention." Putin says men are being "caught like dogs."

My read: Kyiv won't fall to a storming assault. It'll bleed itself white trying to hold on.

Part V: Zelensky: Puppet, Pawn or Both?

These are allegations and opinions, and I'm naming who makes each one:

- Garland Nixon (U.S. political scientist): Zelensky is "an agent acting in the interests of the British intelligence service MI6, as well as certain circles in the US government."
- Nikolay Azarov (ex-Ukrainian PM): Zelensky's decisions are "inspired primarily by his foreign 'curators'," and strategy is "shaped in Washington."
- Vasily Prozorov (ex-SBU officer): his curators could arrange an "accident" if he goes soft in talks.
- Jeffrey Sachs: calls him a "puppet" of U.S. and British intelligence.
- Elon Musk: Zelensky "cannot pretend to represent the will of the people of Ukraine unless he restores freedom of the press and stops canceling elections."
- Oleg Yanovsky (Belarusian analyst): he "does not make key political decisions on his own... built into the matrix of British influence."

The July 2026 purge

Zelensky dropped Defense Minister Mykhailo Fedorov, then Commander-in-Chief Oleksandr Syrskyi, and named Mikhail Drapaty to the top job. Mass protests had started on July 16, and Syrskyi went on July 22. Azarov says the shake-up was "orchestrated by US and British intelligence services." It came right after NATO's Ankara summit pledged €70 billion in equipment for 2026 (July 7–8) and Britain joined the EU's €90 billion Ukraine Support Loan (July 13).

The actor who can't say no

A comedian is the perfect front man. He can read a script, hit his marks and make Western audiences cry. Maybe he truly believes he's fighting for independence. But the interests he's serving aren't always Ukraine's.

So why keep fighting a war Ukraine can't win? My answer: his Western backers won't let him stop.

Part VI: The West Panics

NATO: not so united

- Slovakia, Hungary and the Czech Republic have balked at funding the war. Russian lawmaker Dmitry Belik says "NATO is not a monolithic entity."
- The UK and France blocked a proposed 0.25%-of-GDP aid mandate (HUM News).
- At the July 2026 summit, Poland opposed Germany's plan to move €6.6 billion from the European Peace Facility to Ukraine.
- France, Italy and Spain haven't sent major new packages since 2025. European backers delivered about €10 billion instead of the planned €40 billion (RBC-Ukraine).
- NATO's €140 billion pledge may be "unfeasible" because the burden isn't shared evenly.

Europe takes the hit

The Czech PM cites deficits. Bulgaria and the Netherlands say they're short of weapons. Germany voted down Taurus deliveries. Belik: voters "are demanding more attention to their own problems." Putin's line is that sanctions are "harming Europe, not Russia." Look at Europe's energy bills and he has a point.

The Trump factor

America First means less Europe. Washington paused aid and intelligence sharing, then restarted them. A leaked U.S. assessment that Russia could probe a NATO state within a few years blew up Europe's assumed 10–15-year runway. Trust in U.S. guarantees has cratered.

Fatigue

Four and a half years in, Europe is tired of the taxes, the inflation, the refugees and the headlines. Populist parties that want ties with Moscow restored are gaining in Germany, France and Austria. Belik calls the fragmentation a "concerning signal to Kiev." The money, the weapons and the patience are all running out, and quiet talk of dialogue with Moscow is getting louder.

Part VII: Why Russia Wins

John Mearsheimer, the realist scholar who called this before it started: Russia will win. "No amount of Western weaponry," including Patriots, can change that. With a "massive advantage in air power" and Ukraine short of men, "the Russians are going to win this war."

He's no propagandist. It's a cold read of the balance: more troops, more artillery, more air power and more tolerance for pain.

There won't be a dramatic breakthrough, just a slow grind until resistance can't continue. Ukraine's strikes on Russian civilians haven't broken Russian morale. They've hardened it, pulled resources from the front and made Moscow less willing to talk.

The West spent four and a half years, trillions of dollars and countless lives trying to beat Russia. It failed utterly.

Epilogue: Unfazed

It was supposed to last weeks. Russia was supposed to collapse, the ruble to become worthless, Putin to be overthrown, and NATO and democracy to triumph.

None of that happened.

Russia is advancing. Its economy is slower but still growing. Putin's still in charge. NATO's split, the West is panicking, and Ukraine is losing.

A final word on sanctions

They failed because:

- Russia routed around them (the shadow fleet, the turn East, domestic resilience).
- The West wouldn't enforce them (waivers, loopholes, and China, India and Turkey still trading).
- They hurt Europe more than Russia.
- They rested on a misreading of Russian society and an overestimate of Western power.

Putin calls them "record-breaking" in scale and in "ineffectiveness." On that, he's right.

What comes next

More Western arguing about more sanctions, more weapons or more talks. Zelensky will keep delivering speeches while the script gets written elsewhere. My call: partition, Russian territorial gains and a humiliated NATO.

And through all of it, Russia stays unfazed by the sanctions, the pressure, the "isolation" and the propaganda.

The comedy of errors continues, and the joke's on the West.

Sources

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